The Lab Report: May 2026

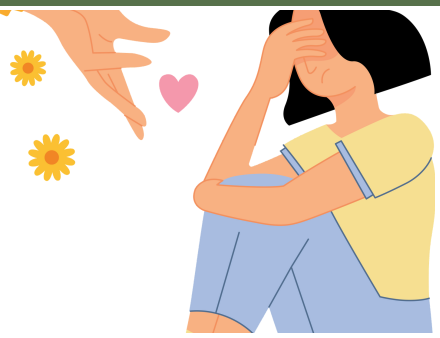
Insights Beyond The Diagnosis

Advanced Skin Cancer & Suicide Risk

Benchmark Diagnostics

A Critical Clinical Insight You Shouldn't Miss

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"Consider psychosocial screening, melanoma diagnosis is associated with increased suicide risk, especially early post-diagnosis."

*Key Findings**

- *Elevated suicide risk in patients with advanced melanoma compared to the general population.*
- *Risk was highest in the early years after diagnosis.*
- *Men and older patients had the greatest risk.*
- *Nonkeratinocyte skin cancers (e.g., Merkel cell carcinoma, adnexal tumors) also showed increased suicide risk, though data were more limited.*
- *Overall trend suggests persistent mental health burden despite advances in treatment.*
- Advanced lesions trigger an acute emotional stress response, which is expected initially.
  - Early phase (first 1–2 weeks):
    - Normal reactions include shock, anxiety, insomnia, and distress
  - Ongoing symptoms (weeks to months):
    - May evolve into Adjustment Disorder, which if unchecked may evolve into major depressive disorder

Clinical Pearls

- Early post-diagnosis window, especially after early stress response phase of 1-2 weeks, is associated with highest vulnerability → target screening here.
- Incorporate mental health screening (brief PHQ-9 or similar) in advanced melanoma follow-ups.
- Red Flags
  - T4 melanoma
  - Merkel cell carcinoma
  - Treatment uncertainty
  - Male patients
  - Elderly

Chen ML, Rezaei SJ, Kim J, Rodriguez C, Swetter SM, O'Hara R, Linos E. Incidence of suicide among melanoma and nonkeratinocyte skin cancer patients in the United States, 2000-2020. J Am Acad Dermatol. 2024 Oct;91(4):715-717. doi: 10.1016/j.jaad.2024.05.028. Epub 2024 May 18. PMID: 38768863.*

"Questions or cases to discuss? We're always happy to review."

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